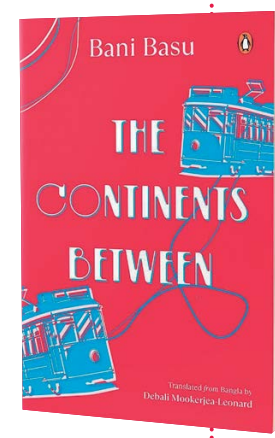
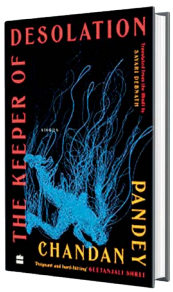
Bani Basu's first novel, written in the late 1980s, actually covered the territory—first- and second-generation Bengali immigrants in America, at home in a country and yet in a perpetual state of yearning—that Jhumpa Lahiri was to make her own later. With a title that translates literally into Birthland and Motherland, the book casts an empathetic eye on the resultant turmoil, without being judgmental or mourning any kind of moral transformation. The authorly sensibility enters the spaces not so much of alienation and loneliness as of the inability to internalise a new culture and values, while also recognising that what has been left behind cannot be returned to. Debali Mookerjea-Leonard brings to her reading both the view of a new generation and the perspective from the US. What the Bengali novel set out to do is, in many senses, completed in this translation.



THE CONTINENTS BETWEEN
By Bani Basu
(Translated from the Bengali by Debali Mookerjea-Leonard)
PENGUIN
₹399; 264 pages

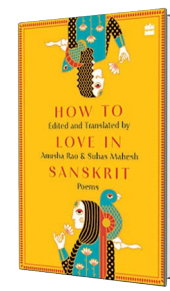


THE KEEPER OF DESOLATION: STORIES
By Chandan Pandey
(Translated from the Hindi by Sayari Debnath)
HARPERCOLLINS
₹299; 240 pages

If Franz Kafka lived in the Gangetic plains in the 21st century, these are the stories he might have written. Chandan Pandey has an unerring instinct for spotting the absurdities in the labyrinth of state power, village bureaucracy, family hierarchies and gender conflicts, and he combines this with a sharply constructed prose that conjures up a living narrator in every story. Everyday life is pushed to its extreme, logical, and preposterous conclusion in every story, forcing us to confront what lies only slightly beneath the surface. Sayari Debnath translates every sentence with a delicate felicity to craft a reading experience in English that could only have been achieved through translation.

Kalidasa and Banabhatta are there, of course, but so are Buddhist and Jain monks, scholars, emperors, and even some modern-day poets. It probably needed this sweeping collection of love poetry originally written in Sanskrit, across centuries, to remind us that those who spoke and lived in this language were not remote historical creatures but bundles of passions and contradictions, as resolute and as uncertain about love as their descendants who speak in other tongues. It is improbable that Anusha Rao and Suhas Mahesh read this material without thumping hearts, beads of perspiration on their brows, and fingers trembling with intensity.

HOW TO LOVE IN SANSKRIT: POEMS
(Translated by Anusha Rao and Suhas Mahesh) HARPER PERENNIAL
₹599; 320 pages





MUDRITHA
By Jissa Jose
(Translated from the Malayalam by Jayasree Kalathil)
Forthcoming from
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 312 pages

FORTHCOMING

A debut novel that begins with a man reporting a missing woman—someone he has never met in real life. The police investigation reaches a dead-end, but the investigator decides to pursue the story on her own—and uncovers the lives of not one but 10 women. And a work of fiction turns into a women's history that travels in and out of their desires, rages, and resistances. The possibilities are utterly intriguing, and the combination of an exciting new talent and one of the finest translators makes for a book that could be a literary landmark in 2025.